

BEYOND THE METRO
Passengers board a flight at Darbhanga Airport, opened under the Udan scheme in 2020

AVIATION | MODIFIED UDAN

UDAN GETS A SECOND WIND

A DECADE AFTER OPENING THE SKIES TO SMALLER TOWNS AND FIRST-TIME FLYERS, A REVAMPED UDAN SCHEME SETS OUT TO MAKE REGIONAL AVIATION WORK FOR THE LONG HAUL

By AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi launched the Modified Udan, or the Ude Desh ka Aam Naagrik, scheme from the new terminal building at Jodhpur Airport on July 4, he presented it as the next step in India's regional aviation story. Approved by the Union Cabinet in March, with an outlay of Rs 28,840 crore for FY27 to FY36, the scheme promises more money and more airports. But read closely, and it is clear that this is not merely an expansion, but a redesign shaped by the lessons of the scheme's first decade.

Launched in 2016, Udan set out to make flying affordable for people who had never boarded an aircraft by connecting India's smaller towns to the national aviation network. By the end of FY26, 663 routes had been made operational across 95 airports, heliports and water aerodromes, reviving 55 abandoned airstrips. More than 16.3 million passengers had travelled on over 344,000 flights under the scheme.

But the numbers masked several structural weaknesses. Despite about Rs 4,600 crore be-